Short Story & Novel Terms

Concept

Read a story through its events, characters, setting and patterns of meaning. Use terms to explain an effect, not just to label it.

Evidence → interpretation

Identify a detail, name the relevant technique, then explain how it shapes the reader's understanding.

Narrator ≠ author

The voice telling the story may have beliefs different from the writer's.

Topic ≠ theme

A topic is a subject such as friendship. A theme is an insight about that subject, supported by the text.

Flexible structures

Not every story follows a neat plot pyramid. An unresolved ending can be deliberate.

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Example 1 | original model

Original mini-story: Jo hides a broken trophy, then admits what happened when a teammate is blamed.

Solution / why it works

1. Conflict: Jo's fear of punishment struggles against her sense of fairness.
2. Character: Her admission suggests a dynamic change if the story shows a meaningful shift in her values.
3. Possible theme: Taking responsibility can require risking one's own reputation.
4. Evidence matters: the theme follows from her choice; "honesty" alone is only a topic.

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Reference | Plot & structure

Short story / novel

Both are fictional narratives. A novel usually allows greater length and complexity; a short story is more concentrated.

Plot

The arrangement of events and actions in a narrative.

Introduction / exposition

Establishes relevant characters, setting and background.

Initiating incident

The event that sets the central action or conflict in motion.

Rising action

Complications develop and pressure grows.

Climax

A major turning point or peak of tension in the central conflict.

Falling action

Consequences of the climax begin to unfold.

Dénouement / resolution

The closing stage; some stories resolve their conflicts, while others leave questions open.

Expository happy / sad ending

The handout's labels for explained, closed endings with happy or sad outcomes.

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Surprise / twist ending

An unexpected development changes the reader's understanding.

Unresolved / indeterminate ending

Some questions remain open; a cliffhanger leaves urgent uncertainty.

Anticlimax

A drop from expected importance or intensity, sometimes deliberately comic.

Chronological order

Events appear in the order in which they occur.

In medias res

The story begins in the middle of the action.

Flashback

Narration moves back to an earlier event.

Foreshadowing

Details hint at developments that will come later.

Suspense

Uncertainty creates anticipation, concern or tension.

Deus ex machina

An unprepared external intervention conveniently resolves a conflict.

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Reference | Characters & characterization

Character

A person, animal or other represented being in a story.

Characterization

The methods used to develop and reveal a character, not merely the cast list.

Protagonist

The central character; not necessarily morally good.

Antagonist

A character or force opposing the protagonist; not necessarily a villain.

Flat / round

Flat: few developed traits. Round: complex, multi-sided characterization.

Dynamic / static

Dynamic (kinetic): changes meaningfully. Static: remains substantially unchanged.

Stock / stereotypical

A familiar type built from conventional traits; can become a cliché.

Cliché

An overused expression, device or idea.

Foil

A contrasting character who helps reveal another's qualities.

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Caricature

Exaggerated traits, often for comic or critical effect.

Hero / anti-hero

A hero displays admired qualities; an anti-hero lacks some conventional heroic qualities.

Direct presentation

The narrator explicitly states a trait: "Leah was patient."

Indirect presentation

A trait is inferred from action, speech, thought, appearance or others' reactions.

Character analysis

Use appearance, speech, actions, thoughts, others' comments and narrator information as clues.

Character sketch

A supported description of personality and values, with specific textual evidence.

Epiphany

A sudden realization that changes understanding.

Dilemma

A difficult choice between alternatives with competing costs.

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Reference | Setting, theme & conflict

Setting

Time, place and social context of the story.

Mood / atmosphere

The emotional quality created through details, events and language.

Theme

An interpretation of the story's insight into people or life; express it as a supported statement.

Topic / moral

Topic: the subject. Moral: a lesson about conduct. A theme need not give advice.

Conflict

A struggle between opposing desires, forces or values.

Internal conflict

A struggle within a character, such as loyalty versus fear.

External conflict

A struggle with an outside force; other characters need not know about it.

Conflict patterns

Person vs person, self, nature/environment, society, technology/machine or supernatural forces.

Universal / personal / cultural symbols

Widely recognized, privately meaningful or associated with a particular culture; meanings still depend on context.

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Reference | Narration, style & irony

Narration / narrator

Narration is the act or result of telling; the narrator is the voice doing the telling.

Point of view

The perspective and access to information through which a story is told.

First person

An "I" narrator participates in or observes events; need not be the protagonist.

Second person

The narrative addresses a "you."

Third-person omniscient

An outside narrator can know multiple characters' thoughts and wider events.

Third-person limited

Access is restricted to one character at a time; also called limited omniscient in the handout.

Objective narration

Reports observable actions and speech without directly revealing thoughts.

Style / stylistic technique

Characteristic choices in diction, syntax, imagery and narrative method.

Dialect

A language variety with patterns of vocabulary, grammar and pronunciation.

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Diction

Word choice. Syntax is the arrangement of words and clauses.

Antithesis

Contrasting ideas in a balanced structure.

Verbal irony

The intended meaning differs from the literal wording, often oppositely.

Situational irony

An outcome meaningfully contradicts an expectation.

Dramatic irony

Readers or viewers know something a character does not.

Paradox

An apparent contradiction that may reveal a truth.

Sarcasm

Cutting or mocking language, often using verbal irony.

Satire

Humour, irony or exaggeration used to criticize behaviour or institutions.

Horatian / Juvenalian satire

Gentler, amused criticism / harsher, indignant criticism.

Stream of consciousness

Writing follows the flow of perceptions, thoughts and associations.

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Symbol / symbolism

Something has significance beyond its literal role; symbolism is the use or pattern of such meanings.

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Reference | Forms of fiction

Allegory

A narrative whose characters and events sustain another level of meaning.

Legend

A traditional account linked to a person, place or purported historical past.

Myth

A culturally significant traditional narrative about origins, powers or beliefs; not simply a synonym for falsehood.

Fable

A brief narrative, often with animal characters, that conveys a moral.

Proverb

A short traditional saying expressing advice or a general observation.

Folk tale

A traditional story transmitted within a community orally or in writing.

Graphic text / graphic novel

Meaning develops through sequential images and words, including their contrasts.

Mystery

A narrative organized around investigating an unexplained event.

Science fiction / fantasy

Speculative science or technology / imagined worlds or supernatural possibilities.

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Romance / historical / contemporary

Love-centred narrative / a past setting / a broadly present-day setting.

Word bank | Theme topic prompts

Abandonment	Grief	Pride
Alienation	Growth and initiation	Race
Ambition	Guilt	Regret
American Dream	Heroism	Rejection
Birth/Childhood	Hope	Religion
Coming of Age	Human relations	Responsibility
Commoditization	Identity	Revenge
Commercialism	Illness	Sacrifice
Commerce	Individual & Nature	Science & Technology
Community	Individual & Society	Sex & Sensuality
Cruelty	Individual & God	Social Class
Death	Innocence	Spirituality
Education	Isolation	Stages of Life
Ethics	Journey & Struggle	Success
Experience	Justice	Suffering
Fall from Grace	Love & Friendship	Survival
Family	Memory	Time
Fate	Nationalism	Tradition
Freedom	Nature	Violence
Futility	Oppression	Work
Gender	Parenthood	

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Word bank | Recurring narrative patterns

Struggle with nature	Life and death	Chance and fate
Pressure from society	Sacrifice and reward	Revenge
Questions of divinity	Shared human needs	A trick
Crime and consequences	A journey	A mystery
Overcoming adversity	Loss of innocence	Identity and belonging
Friendship and sacrifice	Noble sacrifice	Technology and nature
Family bonds	A great battle	Free will and responsibility
Opposing forces / balance	Fall from grace	
Pursuit of love	Love and friendship	

Short Story & Novel Terms

Practice | your turn

1. Identify the protagonist, conflict and turning point in a story you know.

2. Explain how a character can be round but static.

3. Write a theme statement and support it with two details.

4. Distinguish dramatic irony from a surprising ending.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

The protagonist is central to the action; the conflict is the struggle; the turning point changes its direction.

2

Round concerns complexity; static concerns change. A complex character may retain the same values.

3

A theme is a full insight, not a one-word topic or a claim about every person.

4

Dramatic irony involves an audience knowledge gap; a surprise ending changes expectations.

Source & editing note

Grade 12 Short Story and Novel Terms.pdf | 11 supplied pages.

No author identified in the supplied handout. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.

Historical exam asterisks and "new term" markers were omitted; they do not establish current course or exam requirements. Definitions were clarified where the handout oversimplified them.